

Transforming Communication and Collaboration Ecosystem for Early-Stage Researchers Navigating Human-Computer Interaction Research

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Abstract

This provocation explores the entanglement of communication and collaboration in HCI research, early-stage researchers (ESRs), and their relations with the ecosystem. Using a human-centered design approach and an event-centered lens, we take an autobiographical stance. Positioning ESRs as our direct stakeholders, we draw insights from our desk research on three key activities in HCI research: Networking, Doing HCI Research, and Knowledge Sharing. Limited explorations into personal identity realization, domain and interpersonal context familiarization, intersectional identities shaping communication and collaboration experiences, HCI research experiences, and knowledge sharing interventions in non-publication venues emerged as key gaps. Following that, we highlight how our unique intersectional identities entangle with research communication and collaboration using storytelling from critical race theory. We aim to contribute to CSCW and the larger HCI community with our call to action with research and design opportunities for transforming the HCI research ecosystem.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; *Collaborative and social computing*.

Keywords

HCI Research; Early-Stage Researchers; Communication and Collaboration; Critical Race Theory; Storytelling; Communities of Practices

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1 Introduction

"Information sharing in a collaborative research context is both a communication challenge and a collaboration challenge, especially when the research involves multiple research disciplines." [27]

"HCI is now effectively boundless domain." [30]

Research in HCI requires interdisciplinary communication and collaboration among researchers. Communication lies at the "heart of interdisciplinarity" [23]. *"Communication ties interdisciplinary collaborators to one another but also to those of whom they depend for support ... and to those who depend on them for research solutions."* [27]. Research communication and collaboration do not happen in isolation but in an ecosystem. The essence of collaboration is that individuals work together in pursuit of collective goals [27]. Collaborations often consist of researchers who have varying expertise levels due to differing levels of education and experience [11]. Also, *"a notable characteristic observed among researchers, particularly those at early stages of their careers, is a sense of uncertainty about their research identity"* [28]. Therefore, initializing sustainable research communication and collaboration for early-stage researchers (ESRs), scholars up to the point of PhD [2] who just enter the research world, is challenging due to not only interdisciplinary communication and collaboration, but also their identities.

We approach the entanglement of communication and collaboration in HCI research through a human-centered design approach [13] and event-centered [16] lens, categorized into three key activities: **Networking, Doing HCI Research, and Knowledge Sharing**. Specifically, we take an autobiographical stance as our positionalities align with our primary stakeholders' [24]. The following sections first present insights as we review literature, opinions, and existing interventions, while identifying gaps specific to each key activity. Following critical race theory [26], we, as ESRs ourselves, utilize its methodological tool: storytelling, to highlight how intersectional identities are entangled with research communication and collaboration and raise race-awareness in HCI research. Combining different qualitative methods, we focus on the academic and professional positionalities of RI through our desk research, and cultural and linguistic positionalities of RI through our personal stories to show potential gaps in this area. Following that, we present our call to action in the form of research and design opportunities, where we encourage other early-stage researchers, the CSCW community, and the greater HCI community to lead consequential "early-stage researcher-centered" affective, narrative, accessible, and interactive design transformations.

In this provocation, we make some assumptions about our direct stakeholder: ESRs navigating HCI research. Our key assumption is that collaborators seek to empathize with each other and develop a deeper mutual understanding. We assume practice-based and self-identified **researcher identity** of ESRs in this work. We acknowledge that we may not cover the diversity of identities, knowledge systems, value systems, and experiences. Our motivations for this provocation come from a reality we envision, where researchers discover and connect with their collaborators efficiently, co-develop interpersonal contexts, and communication and collaboration become meaningful, engaging, and effortless. We believe achieving this will lead to self-actualization—as designers, researchers, and professionals, being aware of who we are, where we come from, and where we go, is important to make transformative decisions that shape the world around us to be resilient in the face of uncertainty.

2 Activity 1: Networking

A key activity in research communication and collaboration is networking. It begins when researchers realize their identities and position themselves on platforms where they can be discovered and find other potential collaborators. Following this comes the discovery and contact phase where researchers explore collaborators and initiate connections. We postulate that discovery can be driven by a purpose or an event, or both. Purpose-driven discovery includes researchers seeking collaborations for specific requirements, for example, a researcher scanning through a conference program webpage to learn about relevant works and their authors. Finding compatible collaborators goes beyond finding the ones available—researchers may consider a potential collaborator's works and how they correlate with their personal interests, while their scholarly reputation may also be a considerable factor [15]. Event-driven discovery happens where events serve as enablers and provide a site for networking opportunities, for example, academic conferences, where presentation sessions, mixers, and tea breaks, and demonstrations, create venues for engagement and discussions with researchers and their works. There exist various communication channels and communities of practice (CoPs) that facilitate this activity. We can see new developments around making academic conferences more accessible for ESRs, like CHI 2026 featuring a new "Student Mentoring Program", replacing the "Doctoral Consortium" from previous years [3]. Networking is quintessential for ESRs as they navigate their evolving identities, understand the research ecosystem around them, where they fit, and how they can interact within and beyond.

2.1 Networking Systems

Research Networking Systems (RNS) are systems which support individual researchers' efforts to form and maintain optimal collaborative relationships for doing productive research within a specific context [32]. The authors claim, *"To form collaborative relationships, individuals must balance the different motivations of potential collaborators in the context of projects, institutions, and disciplines,"* and, *"Establishing collaborations requires individuals to form impressions of and evaluate potential collaborators based on information beyond expertise and interests"* [32]. Academically direct and indirect networking systems both facilitate research communication and

collaboration. For direct channels, Mazurek et al. claim that there is a significant relationship between social media (SM) presence and Google Scholar citations [21]. Scholars' presence on SM platforms in academia is positively associated with international collaboration [14]. Turning to indirect channels, Qiao and Shih describe SM platforms, particularly the use of QQ and WeChat in China for academic purposes [29]. They mention that social media platforms improve efficiency during informal academic activities such as community building; however, they show inadequacy in functional support for obtaining information and creating new relationships. Proposing an intervention, Archer and Zytka present a social matching system for collaboration originally designed for university faculty with the premise of conveying a willingness to accommodate communication barriers and constraints of non-academic collaborators [5]. Soliman et al. study motivations for interactions, identities, and communication in communities with social hierarchies, and present an intervention in the design space of meronymous communication, that showcases higher communication comfort [36].

2.2 Networking in Events

Events such as academic conferences have a positive effect on promoting researchers to collaborate with each other, with attendee count and field ratings being proportional to new collaborations [37]. Zajdela et al.'s study [39] inquiring into the benefits and drawbacks of virtual and in-person conferences for team formation, community building, and engagement shows that the causal role of formal interaction impacted team formation significantly more in virtual settings, while informal interaction played a larger role at in-person conferences as compared with virtual. A downward trend of international research collaboration (IRC) appeared at the Learning @ Scale (L@S) conference as the authors analyzed works and identified trends [9]. With WHO2CHAT, Park et al. present an intervention designed for social networking in academic settings and how it lowers social barriers as they cover various strategies and steps in social matching, from 'modeling' to 'meeting' [28].

2.3 Research Gaps around Activity 1

We reviewed various theories, frameworks, and interventions in place for purpose-driven and event-driven discovery. However, we observed a minimal focus on ESRs as the direct stakeholders, their research ecosystem, context familiarization with the facets of HCI research, and identity realization and representation. Analyses into the complex systems that underpin events like academic conferences and how ESRs experience each facet of networking also emerge as gaps to investigate. These gaps may exist because of untapped 'early-stage researcher-centered' studies investigating their research contexts.

3 Activity 2: Doing HCI Research

Another key activity in research communication and collaboration is doing HCI research. This activity may be experienced differently by different ESRs, as backgrounds, cultures, experiences, and available resources can be varying and diverse [27]. Collaborators may start by learning about each other's backgrounds, expectations, motivations, and working styles as they iterate through research

ideation, planning, experimentation, data sharing and analysis, and reporting findings.

3.1 Navigating and Accommodating Differences

Differences in cultural contexts, skills, and experience levels orchestrate the collaboration dynamics, and there may be some pedagogical aspects involved in reaching a common ground and building shared understanding [11, 27]. Toolkits such as *common::ground* [34] present a gamified intervention to achieve interpersonal connections in culturally diverse groups with comfort and engagement. Sharing research data and working with tools in interdisciplinary groups are integral to many research workflows [10, 11, 17]. Kang and Rzeszutarski discuss the challenges qualitative UX research practitioners face with data sharing and tool adoption when navigating differences in background, knowledge, and priority of different teams [17]. Frequent communication in collaboration emerged as a key strategy to achieve consensus as it positively influences practitioners' tool choices and data management. For research best practices, Marijan and Sen in their work aimed to support researchers and practitioners in establishing and running collaboration projects present a set of actionable patterns and anti-patterns [20].

3.2 Research Gaps around Activity 2

We reviewed the intents, behaviors, practices, and outcomes involved in research collaborations and interventions designed to bridge the experience gaps. We found a dearth of works exploring ESRs and how their unique intersectional identities shape their experiences communicating and collaborating while doing HCI research. Researchers' experiences through the HCI research stages like planning, ideation, brainstorming, concepting, prototyping, testing, and consolidation of findings remain underexplored. These gaps may be explored through qualitative studies to collect the rich contexts with each individual experience. There are also opportunities for extensive investigations involving ESRs and other ecosystem stakeholders to co-design guidelines, strategies, practices, and interventions. Longitudinal data on these gaps can leverage the design of an intervention into making research communication and collaboration more meaningful, engaging, and effortless.

4 Activity 3: Knowledge Sharing

The third key activity in research communication and collaboration is knowledge sharing. In this activity, researchers diffuse their knowledge through different channels. This activity is important for ESRs to gain feedback and establish new connections with new supervisors and collaborators. Attempts have been made to empower this activity within academia. According to the [6], researchers find that GIFs have great potential in terms of how design researchers produce and disseminate knowledge. In the [25], Noppe et al. propose learning from fandom and fan activists to enable a more accessible scholarship and increase overall visibility and enthusiasm. A visible act of collaboration is co-authorship, where two or more researchers contribute to a publication [15]. In [33], the University of St. Gallen hosted CHI Together to help participants collaborate efficiently and manage the stress before the CHI deadline. Beyond academic publication venues, researchers also explore knowledge diffusion channels towards industry [8, 18], and

government [31]. The best pictorial in DIS'24 speculates on how the DIS community could circulate knowledge within and beyond academic publication venues [22]. A recent study discusses Alternate Research Outcomes (AROs) and their unique values of being translational, situational, transparent, and initiatory [38]. AROs can be considerable options for researchers who find traditional research outcomes less accessible for any set of reasons. We also see paradigm shifts in making traditional publication-based research venues more accessible: ACM announced earlier this year that it will adopt the Open Access (OA) publishing model by the end of 2025, making all eligible research open-source [4].

4.1 Research Gaps around Activity 3

Research into non-publication venues and alternative research outcomes seems to be previously underexplored but now a growing space for discussions. Although we have seen public scholarship practices such as by Dr. Casey Fiesler on YouTube [1], research and design for public scholars on social media seem to not have been fully conducted. This might be because new forms of knowledge dissemination and diffusion are still in their early stages to emerge as established venues. To summarize, for the knowledge sharing activity, we witness knowledge diffusion channels both within and beyond academia. However, the space of non-publication-based AROs presents future research opportunities.

5 Critical Race Theory for HCI: Personal Stories

We relate our stories to highlight how researchers' identity is entangled with research communication and collaboration utilizing storytelling from critical race theory for HCI [26]. The concept of identity is characterized by intersectionality, reflexivity, association, and evolution [7, 26]. Researchers' identities, subjectivities, values, and experiences through time shape their positionalities [35]. Our following stories mainly incorporate two tenets (3 & 6) of critical race theory [26]: *"Each person represents a unique and even potentially conflicting set of overlapping identities"*, and, *"There is a uniqueness to the voice of color, and storytelling is a means for it to be heard"*. **The convergence of these two tenets guides our personal stories**, highlighting that intersectional identities create unique contexts, and the counterstories can challenge and displace dominant or homogeneous narratives. We present a disclosure to our audience of the conditions of our knowing: our research team comes from different positions of privilege and marginalization. We recognize that there are many intersections of race and marginalization that we do not experience. Our experiences cannot and do not represent everyone who shares a particular identity. The following stories are individual stories narrated by the authors of this provocation, written in first-person to emphasize the stories' specificity and personal impact.

5.1 Story 1: English as a dominant language in HCI

I attended and received my academic training from an international joint venture university in the Global South. Even the majority of my research training has been in the Western tradition, as the language of instruction in our university is English. This tension between my mother tongue and English has always woven into

my research communication and collaboration. English is the dominant language in HCI. The assumption of writing in English is so prevalently embedded in major conferences CHI and CSCW that the official websites of those conferences do not include language instructions. These elephant-in-the-room language barriers filter out nuances of other cultures and raise the bar for research from other cultures to communicate and collaborate. This assumption of sociomaterial entanglement can also be witnessed in the research tools I use. At this moment, when I am writing this provocation, I cannot type my name in Chinese characters unless going through the whole process of setting and resetting. Representing the Chinese name in Alphabet (pinyin) is not adequate due to the characteristics of Chinese, as the same alphabet can refer to millions of Chinese characters. That is to say, I could not even represent my name in its real form. To conclude, my counterstory shows that the research communication and collaboration dominated by English is inadequate to represent the basic identity, the name, of researchers from different language systems.

5.2 Story 2: Navigating my HCI research journey through evolving context bubbles

I attended a research-based state university, situated in the capital city of a global-south country, where the language of instruction was English and the research culture was Western-influenced. As a native resident, I am familiarized with the local cultures and ways of being, my native language (Hindi), and the systems I interact with. I began my HCI research journey as a lab-affiliated researcher, collaborating with cross-department teams in my institutional research labs. My approach to collaboration comprised both purpose-driven approach and facilitator-driven team-formations. Success in research to me majorly meant having the opportunity to publish and present my works and connect with other researchers at academic conferences. I currently attend a public R1 university, situated in an urban city of a global-north country. My bilingual fluency in English, understanding of my discipline-specific attributes, and curiosity to learn new perspectives helped with my contextual transitions. After moving countries, engaging with the individualism-forward, diverse society was a new experience; however, several contextual shifts occurring at once caused a temporary slowdown in my progress with my research. As I eventually positioned myself around my new context bubble, I observed my personal, social, and cultural contexts evolving. My current research trajectory is shaped by my consciousness and reflexive understanding of all my prior experiences, discipline correspondences, value system, interests, motivations, and visions. As I recognize my identities, roles, and potential as a multidisciplinary HCI researcher, I now hold long-term goals and think about the impact of my works deeply. However, retrospectively, it does not feel to me that my current research ecosystem is designed to allow me to express through my prior context bubble.

6 CTA: Research and Design Opportunities

Through this provocation, we explored early-stage researchers and their relations with the HCI research ecosystem. We drew insights from literature, opinions, and interventions across three key activities in HCI research. Interpersonal context building emerged

as a prominent gap in our desk research. There exist elementary explorations into the initial period after establishing connections with collaborators. Exploring affective communication theories and practices will provide the design explorations in helping researchers build a collective identity and handle points of conflict with deeper empathy and mutual understanding [27]. Our work going forward includes research into the elements that contribute towards identity realization and representation as researchers, communicators, and collaborators. We plan to conduct a more comprehensive analysis of the HCI research ecosystem in our future research. Design methods such as stakeholder analysis from Value Sensitive Design (VSD) [12] and conceptual frameworks such as MoCA [19] will be used to articulate the HCI ecosystem to HCI communities [12].

Following human-centered design, we propose future contributors to explore consequential interventions to empower and nurture ESRs. We invite researchers and designers to take an "early-stage researcher-centered" approach, follow a VSD mindset, consider the larger ecosystem and the entanglements that exist within it. By sharing our personal stories, we encourage this paper's audience to join us in this practice. More efforts can be made to improve accessibility in research communication and collaboration. We have seen promising practices from ACM and IEEE to offer financial support for diversity, equity, inclusivity, and accessibility. A preferable research and design direction we envision in this space is a communication and collaboration system that is more inclusive to speakers and writers of non-native English languages, with emphasis on the diversity of language nuances, references, modalities, and narratives.

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